

consent was not required. The bridegroom paid a bride price for his spouse, while her father provided a dowry. After marriage, both remained the property of the wife. In this respect, Viking marriage laws were more favorable to women than those in Christian Europe, where a woman's property passed to her husband after marriage. Also in contrast with contemporary Christian practice, both partners had equal rights to divorce if a marriage proved unsuccessful. These rights, however, were gradually eroded after Christianity was adopted across Scandinavia.

Although Viking men were not expected to be faithful, a wife's adultery was deemed a serious matter as it dishonored her husband. If a husband found his wife and a lover together, he had the right to kill both of them on the spot. While Viking raiders became associated with rape and plunder, a man who raped a freewoman was outlawed for his crime. Slave women, on the other hand, had

**"... IT'S NOT A MAN'S
BUSINESS TO
BOTHER ABOUT
KITCHEN MATTERS."**

NJÁLS SAGA, ICELAND, 13TH CENTURY

no legal protection: they were viewed as property and their owners did not need to seek their consent before having sex with them. Slave women were sometimes sacrificed as grave gifts to follow their owners into the afterlife—as was the case in the Oseberg ship burial near Tønsberg, Norway.

▼ **Reconstructed picture**

A tapestry from the Oseberg burial—a richly detailed and expensive grave gift—depicts mythological scenes, including women carrying spears.

